why Indian troops got involved in the plateau – even though Indian troops had crossed over into non-Indian territory to defend Bhutanese claims.[39] Based on this episode, it is likely that India will throw its diplomatic weight behind Japan in most scenarios where the latter might find itself in a dispute with China. This type of diplomatic support is part and parcel of the core bargain between India and Japan, according to which Japan invests in India's long-term capabilities and India publicly endorses Japan's vision for the future of the Indo-Pacific while also supporting Japan diplomatically in any potential contingency involving China.

There is, of course, a limit to India's support for Japan, and that is the point at which Beijing may decide to punish Delhi economically or diplomatically for its embrace of Tokyo. In 2007, for example, China reacted negatively to the Malabar naval exercises held in the Bay of Bengal (involving India, the United States, Japan, Australia, and Singapore) and Shinzo Abe's desire to form the Quad.[40] Delhi was quick to reassure Beijing and subsequently eschewed multilateral naval exercises in Indian waters for the next seven years, until Prime Minister Singh officially invited Japan to re-join the Malabar exercises in 2014. Prime Minister Modi, while determined to adopt a firmer stance toward China – as evinced during the Doklam crisis – has publicly reaffirmed China's importance to India as a neighbouring major power and major trade partner, essentially alternating between "engagement at the summit level" on the one hand and "a series of provocations" on the other.[41] There is thus a recognition on New Delhi's part of the importance of maintaining relations with Beijing on an even keel except when it comes to outright challenges to India's interests or sovereignty. Typically, this means avoiding situations that might lead to the kind of official protest lodged by China in response to the potential formation of a Quad in 2007.